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Rachel

Jacob's beloved wife, who waited long for children and died giving birth to Benjamin.

Rachel was the younger daughter of Laban and the wife Jacob loved most. Jacob met her at a well, tending her father's sheep, and worked fourteen years to marry her. Yet for years she had no children while her sister Leah had many, and the sisters became rivals. At last God remembered Rachel, and she bore Joseph. Later, near Bethlehem, she died giving birth to Benjamin. Her story holds love and longing, jealousy and faith. Jeremiah pictured her weeping for her children, and Matthew heard that cry again at the birth of Jesus.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Rachel</i> , meaning "ewe," a female sheep
Family	Younger daughter of Laban; sister of Leah; wife of Jacob (Genesis 29:16, 28)
Children	Joseph and Benjamin (Genesis 35:24)
Her maid	Bilhah, mother of Dan and Naphtali (Genesis 29:29; 30:3–8)
Key places	The well near Haran; the road to Ephrath, which is Bethlehem (Genesis 29:4–10; 35:19)
Main passages	Genesis 29:6–31:35; 35:16–20
Later references	Ruth 4:11; 1 Samuel 10:2; Jeremiah 31:15
New Testament	Matthew 2:18

"And God remembered Rachel, and God hearkened to her, and opened her womb."
Genesis 30:22, KJV

The life of Rachel

Genesis gives no dates or ages for Rachel. The order below follows the text. Joseph was born near the end of Jacob's first fourteen years in Haran (Genesis 30:25–26).

At the well	● Meets Jacob
	Rachel comes with her father's sheep. Jacob rolls the stone from the well, waters her flock, kisses her and weeps. She runs home to tell her father. <i>Genesis 29:6–12</i>
Seven years	● Loved and waited for
	Jacob offers to work seven years for Rachel. "They seemed unto him but a few days, for the love he had to her." <i>Genesis 29:18–20</i>
The wedding week	● Married after Leah
	Laban gives Leah to Jacob first. A week later Rachel becomes Jacob's wife too, and he works seven more years for her. <i>Genesis 29:21–30</i>
Childless years	● Bilhah's sons
	Rachel envies her sister and gives her maid Bilhah to Jacob. Bilhah bears Dan and Naphtali, and Rachel names them. <i>Genesis 30:1–8</i>
At last	● Joseph is born
	God remembers Rachel and she bears a son. She names him Joseph and prays, "The LORD shall add to me another son." <i>Genesis 30:22–24</i>
Leaving Haran	● Takes the images
	While Laban is away shearing sheep, Rachel steals his household images. When he searches her tent, she sits on them and stays hidden. <i>Genesis 31:19, 33–35</i>
Near Bethlehem	● Dies giving birth
	On the road to Ephrath she has a hard labor. Dying, she names the baby Benoni, but Jacob calls him Benjamin. Jacob sets a pillar on her grave. <i>Genesis 35:16–20</i>

Key activities

No one knows why Rachel took her father's images. Some suggest she wanted their protection or still trusted them. Others link them to family inheritance, or think she simply wanted to hurt Laban. Genesis does not say.

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- 1 **Kept her father's sheep.** She was a working shepherdess when Jacob first saw her. *Genesis 29:9*
 - 2 **Was deeply loved.** Jacob served fourteen years for her and loved her more than Leah. *Genesis 29:18, 30*
 - 3 **Cried out for children.** In her envy she told Jacob, "Give me children, or else I die." *Genesis 30:1-2*
 - 4 **Struggled with her sister.** At Naphtali's birth she said, "With great wrestlings have I wrestled with my sister, and I have prevailed." *Genesis 30:8*
 - 5 **Bargained for mandrakes.** She traded a night with Jacob to Leah in exchange for Reuben's mandrakes. *Genesis 30:14-16*
 - 6 **Received God's answer.** God remembered her, and she said, "God hath taken away my reproach." *Genesis 30:22-23*
 - 7 **Stole and hid the images.** She took Laban's household gods and kept them hidden during his search. *Genesis 31:19, 34-35*
 - 8 **Gave her life for a son.** She died bearing Benjamin, the only one of Jacob's sons born in Canaan. *Genesis 35:16-19*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Rachel.

Old Testament

Genesis 29:6–35:20	The main account
Genesis 48:7	Jacob grieves that she died on the way to Ephrath
Ruth 4:11	"Like Rachel and like Leah," builders of Israel's house
1 Samuel 10:2	"Rachel's sepulchre in the border of Benjamin"
Jeremiah 31:15–17	"Rahel weeping for her children"
Echo: 1 Samuel 1:19–20	Hannah too longed for a child

New Testament

Matthew 2:16–18	Herod's killings in Bethlehem: "Rachel weeping for her children"
Tradition	Rachel's Tomb near Bethlehem; some place the site farther north

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Rachel say to Jacob in Genesis 30:1, and how did he answer?
2. *Understand:* Rachel had Jacob's love; Leah had children. How did each want what the other had?
3. *Apply:* What do you tend to envy, and how could you bring that longing to God?
4. *Apply:* How could your group encourage someone who is still waiting?